Noise Covariance as Representation Geometry: One Metric, Four Architecture Classes

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Abstract

Label-free scientific reconstruction learns representations from measured observations alone — self-supervision in which the instrument-characterized noise covariance, not an augmentation policy, decides which residuals are informative. For Gaussian noise, inverse covariance is the likelihood-consistent reconstruction metric. Every ingredient here is classical — generalized least squares, the matched filter, weighted PCA, the linear-autoencoder/PCA correspondence, multilinear PCA — and we introduce no new estimator; we organize them as a pair $(\Sigma^{-1}, \mathcal{F})$, the likelihood fixing the residual geometry and the architecture the admissible representation class. Holding the metric fixed, we walk $\mathcal{F}$ up four rungs: optimal filtering, an unrestricted rank-k linear projection, a Kronecker-separable two-factor projection, and factored attention. At the linear rungs the metric question has a closed-form answer and reverses in practice: models sharing an architecture and differing only in the training metric rank oppositely under raw MSE and the likelihood residual (ten seeds, paired intervals excluding zero; a twenty-seed white-noise control is exactly zero). At the attention rung the reversal does not appear, and the obvious explanation — a near-degenerate whitening there — is ruled out by measurement. The metric fixes the geometry; whether that choice bites is a property of the instrument and the representation.

1 Introduction

Many scientific instruments produce abundant measurements but no labels or clean targets, so each observation is its own training signal while an instrument-derived noise model says which discrepancies are meaningful; the observations are continuous, multi-channel time series whose uncertainty varies across frequencies, sensors, and acquisition conditions. Standard mean-squared error (MSE) weighs all residual coordinates equally; under colored or correlated noise a large residual can lie in a poorly measured direction while a small one in a low-noise direction is statistically decisive. The measurement covariance is therefore a measurement-model prior fixing the geometry of reconstruction error, distinct from a conservation law, equivariance, or simulator constraint [Bronstein et al., 2021, Karniadakis et al., 2021].

This complements self-supervised reconstruction without clean targets [Batson and Royer, 2019, Yaman et al., 2020, Gruber et al., 2025]; unlike augmentation- or masking-based self-supervision [Chen et al., 2020, He et al., 2022], which presupposes nuisance structure that can be simulated, measurement noise supplies that structure directly.

Every individual link here is classical, and we state the boundary plainly. Inverse-covariance weighting is generalized least squares [Aitken, 1936] and, at rank one, the matched or optimal filter [Turin, 1960, Kay, 1993, Szymkowiak et al., 1993]; that literature fixes the weighting but assumes a *known*, one-dimensional template. The latent-variable line relaxes the signal model but not the noise model:

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probabilistic PCA assumes isotropic noise [Tipping and Bishop, 1999] and factor analysis a diagonal covariance [Rubin and Thayer, 1982, Roweis, 1998], while weighted low-rank models [Bailey, 2012, Allen et al., 2014] and the linear-autoencoder/PCA correspondence [Baldi and Hornik, 1989] are established, as is multilinear PCA [Lu et al., 2008]. *We introduce no new estimator.* What is new is the arrangement: placing these in one Σ^{-1} metric as a ladder of admissible representation classes, the exact condition under which the Kronecker restriction is lossless (Proposition 2), and the observation that a factored-attention network is that same restriction relaxed to a nonlinear map — so the metric question does not stop where closed-form analysis does.

We ask: *what geometry should a label-free scientific reconstruction use under structured noise, and how should that geometry interact with the architecture that expresses the representation?* We organize reconstruction methods as a pair $(\Sigma^{-1}, \mathcal{F})$: the measurement likelihood fixes the residual geometry Σ^{-1}, while the architecture fixes the admissible representation class $\mathcal{F}$ — including, for structured measurements, the axis along which the data are tokenized (Section 3). Holding Σ^{-1} fixed, we walk $\mathcal{F}$ up the four rungs of Section 3: optimal filtering, unrestricted rank-k linear (Proposition 1), Kronecker-separable two-factor (Proposition 2), and factored attention. The first three rungs admit closed-form analysis; the fourth is settled empirically. Under non-isotropic noise, raw MSE and the likelihood residual can rank equal-capacity models in opposite orders (Section 2). Nonlinear representation classes beyond attention, distribution shift, and adaptive sampling remain future work.

2 Covariance-weighted representation geometry

Let $x_i = s_i + n_i \in \mathbb{R}^d$ be a mean-subtracted observation with $n_i \sim \mathcal{N}(0, \Sigma)$ and $\Sigma \succ 0$ (mean handling in Appendix B.2). For a candidate reconstruction $\hat{s}_i$, the Gaussian negative log-likelihood is, up to constants,

$$\chi^2(\hat{s}_i) = (x_i - \hat{s}_i)^\top \Sigma^{-1} (x_i - \hat{s}_i). \tag{1}$$

Whitening, $\tilde{x}_i = \Sigma^{-1/2} x_i$, maps this quadratic form to $\|\tilde{x}_i - \hat{\tilde{s}}_i\|_2^2$: the noise-aware problem is Euclidean projection in whitened coordinates and Σ^{-1}-orthogonal projection in measurement coordinates. We report the mean per-trace residual $N^{-1} \sum_i \chi_i^2$ or the per-coordinate normalized residual $\bar{\chi}^2 = (Nd)^{-1} \sum_{i=1}^N \chi^2(\hat{s}_i)$, stating explicitly which normalization is used.

The theory treats Σ as specified; in practice it comes from calibration or noise-only records, estimated and regularized without evaluation data, and a misspecified Σ defines a misspecified geometry (Appendix B.2).

Proposition 1 (Noise-weighted projection bridge)**.** *Under the model above, OF, rank-k covariance-weighted PCA (CW-PCA), and a tied noise-aware linear autoencoder minimize Eq.* (1) *over different admissible subspaces. OF fixes a rank-one template; CW-PCA learns a rank-k subspace; and the tied autoencoder parameterizes the same learned projection when its encoder is the Σ^{-1}-adjoint of its decoder.*

Proof sketch. Whitening reduces the problem to ordinary rank-k approximation, so every minimizer spans a leading eigenspace of the whitened sample covariance; at rank one this is the optimal filter, and the tied Σ^{-1}-adjoint encoder follows from the same geometry. Unlike the latent-variable precedents of Section 1, the full covariance is kept specified. Details in Appendix A.

Metric reversal. Raw MSE replaces Σ^{-1} by I and is likelihood-correct only when $\Sigma = \sigma^2 I$; under colored noise MSE follows raw variance while Eq. (1) emphasizes high-information directions. Consequently, two equal-rank models can satisfy $\mathrm{MSE}(A) < \mathrm{MSE}(B)$ but $\chi^2(A) > \chi^2(B)$, with learned subspaces nearly orthogonal after whitening. This is not an evaluation paradox: each model is optimal in a different geometry.

3 The architecture ladder

Holding the metric fixed, we walk the representation class $\mathcal{F}$ of the pair $(\Sigma^{-1}, \mathcal{F})$ up four rungs. Rungs 1–3 are analysed in general two-axis form and evidenced synthetically in Section 4; rung 4 is evidenced on the short-time Fourier transform (STFT) band–frame plane of a public benchmark, where Σ^{-1} is diagonal in frequency by measurement (Section 4).

Rung 1: rank-one fixed template (optimal filtering). Fixing the signal to a known template s_0, the likelihood-optimal reconstruction is the optimal filter (OF) amplitude of Section 2 [Gatti and Manfredi, 1986, Turin, 1960]; the representation class is a single direction and the metric question has a closed-form answer.

Rung 2: unrestricted rank-k linear. Replacing the fixed template with a learned rank-k subspace gives covariance-weighted PCA (CW-PCA), which is also the tied noise-aware linear autoencoder: both minimize the likelihood residual over the full Grassmannian $\mathrm{Gr}(k, n_1 n_2)$ of a two-axis measurement (Proposition 1), with reconstruction $\hat{s} = PP^\top \Sigma^{-1} x$ for a learned-subspace basis P.

Rung 3: Kronecker-separable two-axis projection (NFPA). NFPA restricts rung 2's projection to separable factors of a two-axis measurement $Z_i \in \mathbb{R}^{n_1 \times n_2}$ — sensor channel $\times$ time in the controlled synthetic study, frequency band $\times$ time frame on the public benchmark. It learns orthonormal bases $U_1 \in \mathbb{R}^{n_1 \times k_1}$ and $U_2 \in \mathbb{R}^{n_2 \times k_2}$, with code $C_i = U_1^\top Z_i U_2$ and reconstruction $\hat{Z}_i = U_1 U_1^\top Z_i U_2 U_2^\top$, i.e. $\mathrm{vec}(\hat{Z}_i) = (U_2 U_2^\top \otimes U_1 U_1^\top)\mathrm{vec}(Z_i)$; the joint representation is $\mathrm{range}(U_1) \otimes \mathrm{range}(U_2)$, and the admissible family is the embedded product $\mathrm{Gr}(k_1, n_1) \times \mathrm{Gr}(k_2, n_2) \hookrightarrow \mathrm{Gr}(k_1 k_2, n_1 n_2)$.

Proposition 2 (Kronecker-restricted bridge)**.** *NFPA minimizes the CW-PCA/tied-autoencoder objective restricted to Kronecker-separable two-axis subspaces. Its optimum equals the unrestricted CW-PCA optimum if and only if at least one rank-$k_1 k_2$ CW-PCA minimizer has such a separable subspace.*

Proof sketch. The Kronecker form above is the orthogonal projector onto $\mathrm{range}(U_1) \otimes \mathrm{range}(U_2)$ in whitened coordinates, so NFPA is the whitened rank-$k_1 k_2$ objective restricted to that product; equality holds precisely when that set contains an unrestricted minimizer, and otherwise the gap is the cost of the architecture prior, not a failure of the metric — a cost measurable by fitting rungs 2 and 3 at matched rank and comparing held-out likelihood residuals, which Section 4 does. This is a covariance-aware member of the multilinear-PCA family [Lu et al., 2008], not a new factorization. When either factor is full rank the restriction is inactive and rung 3 reduces to rung 2; at $k_1 = k_2 = 1$ it recovers rung 1 (Corollary 1, Appendix A).

Rung 4: factored attention. Rung 3's two-factor restriction, instantiated on the band–frame plane, reads as $\mathrm{range}(U_f) \otimes \mathrm{range}(U_m)$ — separable frequency-band and time-frame factors; rung 4's transformer performs intra-band temporal attention over frames, then cross-band attention. These are the same factorization at different levels of nonlinearity, in the same coordinates, and Σ^{-1} is diagonal in exactly the basis the first factor indexes: on this benchmark a stationary-PSD model fits the readout noise ($\chi^2/\mathrm{dof} = 1.0002$, all gates passed; Section 4). This is a tokenization principle, not a convenience: choose the token axis in which Σ^{-1} is diagonal and the likelihood metric becomes a per-token weight rather than a dense coupling across tokens. The model accordingly treats real and imaginary components as two features of each of 328 physical-frequency tokens, not as 656 unrelated rows. The rung-4 model is a transformer [Vaswani et al., 2017] over frame patches [Nie et al., 2023], with rotary embeddings on the temporal axis [Su et al., 2024] and learned embeddings across bands; the metric question is posed empirically (Section 4). Injecting the optimal-filter statistic into the forward pass [Sjostrom, 2026] is compatible with this architecture but not evaluated here.

4 Evidence

Metric reversal in the linear rungs. A 30-seed rank-two synthetic benchmark and a ten-seed white-noise control establish the reversal at rung 2; on one public TIDMAD file with an injected reference [Fry et al., 2024] the weighted residual agrees with the recorded truth against raw MSE — one file, not replicated at a confirmatory file (Appendix B.2). The consolidated evidence below supersedes these. TIDMAD's diagnostics also show the signal is not a fixed low-dimensional subspace (the tone sweeps; one file is two-tone), so the architecture binds; rung 4 lifts it.

NFPA under channel compression. Rung 3 is consolidated at $C = 8 > k_c = 2$ channels and matched total rank $k = k_c k_t = 6$: NFPA, an isotropically trained factored baseline of the same architecture, CW-PCA, and ordinary PCA, fitted on the same ten seeds. Because NFPA and the isotropic baseline share an architecture and differ only in the training metric, their paired

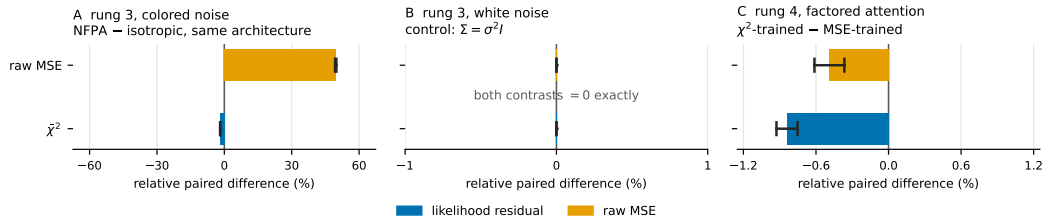


Figure 1: Paired contrasts at fixed architecture, as relative differences with percentile bootstrap 95% intervals (10^4 resamples). **A**, rung 3, colored noise, ten seeds: the two metrics point in *opposite* directions — metric reversal. **B**, white-noise control, twenty seeds: exactly zero. **C**, rung 4, fifty held-out evaluations on a matched step grid: both point the *same* way — no reversal. Computed from archived records by `scripts/make_rps_figure.py`.

contrast isolates the metric. It reverses: NFPA is better under the likelihood residual (paired difference -0.0192, seed-level bootstrap 95% interval $[-0.0194, -0.0190]$) and worse under raw MSE ($+0.0034$, $[+0.0034, +0.0034]$), both intervals excluding zero over ten seeds. Against the unrestricted CW-PCA the held-out likelihood residual differs by -0.0026 ($[-0.0026, -0.0025]$) — a finite-sample difference, not evidence the Kronecker restriction is intrinsically superior. In the twenty-seed white-noise control both contrasts are zero to machine precision (0.000000, $[0, 0]$), isolating covariance geometry rather than rank or optimization as the cause. The single-split $C = k_c = 2$ run is in Appendix B.2.

Rung 4: the metric in a factored-attention network. One factored-attention architecture is trained on the TIDMAD readout with two objectives differing only in the metric — `T-mse` on the unwhitened spectrogram, `T-chi2` on the Σ^{-1}-weighted residual — at matched data, budget, seed handling and evaluation grid. *The reversal does not appear at this rung.* Over fifty held-out evaluations the Σ^{-1}-trained arm is better on *both* criteria: paired difference -1.15×10^{-4} on the normalized likelihood residual ($[-1.27, -1.03] \times 10^{-4}$) and -57.2 on raw MSE ($[-71.6, -42.6]$), both intervals excluding zero but the second in the direction opposite to prediction. These evaluations lie along one training trajectory and are autocorrelated, so the intervals understate uncertainty; the last-ten contrast agrees in sign on both metrics. The release's coarse denoising score does not separate the arms: paired difference -1.0×10^{-3}, window and file-block bootstrap intervals $[-3.3, +1.4]$ and $[-4.6, +2.4] \times 10^{-3}$, both spanning zero; both arms sit far below the published baselines (Appendix B.1); Figure 1 shows all three contrasts. A degenerate metric would explain it, and we tested for one: J spans a factor 441 over the modelled band and the whitening weights have coefficient of variation 0.69 — the same order as the synthetic rung-3 geometry where the reversal *is* observed (1.10; the white control is 0 by construction) — so the metric is comparably non-degenerate at both rungs, and we read the absence as a property of this instantiation, not of the ladder: at this capacity and budget the architecture absorbs the weighting, with one seed per arm.

Transfer of the noise model. On a public gravitational-wave strain release [LIGO Scientific Collaboration and Virgo Collaboration, 2016, Macleod et al., 2021], a whitened score matching its reference form to 10^{-12} and calibrated on stationary synthetic noise (dispersion 1.15) is seven to nine times over-dispersed on real H1 and L1 strain (9.42, 8.83; leave-one-out 1.77, 7.29). A covariance model can be correctly implemented, validated synthetically, and still fail to transfer: implementation identity is not calibration, and the transfer step is where a learned reconstruction geometry is falsified.

Limitations. The ladder answers the metric question in closed form at the linear rungs and empirically at rung 4, where the reversal is not observed. Four caveats bound that evidence. Rung 4 is one seed per arm, so its held-out differences are contrasts over evaluations rather than evidence about seed variability; both arms sit far below the published baselines; and the objectives there are measurably non-degenerate, so what does account for the absence is unknown. The linear-rung TIDMAD reversal is not replicated at a confirmatory file. Stationary-PSD adequacy is per-instrument: adequate on the TIDMAD readout ($\chi^2/\mathrm{dof} = 1.0002$), failing on gravitational-wave strain. The $C = 8 > k_c = 2$ result uses an oracle covariance, bounding what a correctly specified Σ buys rather than an estimated one.

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A Proof details

A.1 Noise-weighted projection bridge

Let $W = \Sigma^{-1/2}P$. The constraint $P^\top\Sigma^{-1}P = I_k$ becomes $W^\top W = I_k$, and the reconstruction satisfies

$$\Sigma^{-1/2}\hat{s} = \Sigma^{-1/2}PP^\top\Sigma^{-1}x = WW^\top\tilde{x}.$$

The empirical loss is therefore $N^{-1}\sum_i \|\tilde{x}_i - WW^\top\tilde{x}_i\|_2^2$. By Rayleigh–Ritz, every minimizer spans a leading rank-k eigenspace of the whitened sample covariance. Mapping back yields the CW-PCA subspace. The objective depends on W only through $WW^\top$, so W is identified up to an orthogonal rotation.

A.2 Kronecker-restricted bridge

For every $Z \in \mathbb{R}^{C\times T}$, the vectorization identity gives

$$\mathrm{vec}(U_cU_c^\top ZU_tU_t^\top) = (U_tU_t^\top \otimes U_cU_c^\top)\mathrm{vec}(Z).$$

The Kronecker product is a symmetric idempotent matrix of rank k_ck_t, hence the orthogonal projector onto $\mathrm{range}(U_t)\otimes\mathrm{range}(U_c)$. NFPA is thus the ordinary whitened rank-k_ck_t projection loss restricted to product subspaces. The restricted and unrestricted minima coincide exactly when an unrestricted minimizing projector belongs to this subset.

A.3 Rank-one correspondence

For $Z_i = A_ivt^\top + \epsilon_i$ with isotropic whitened noise and a unique leading signal eigendirection separated by a nonzero eigengap, the population second moment has leading vectorized direction $(t\otimes v)/(\|t\|\|v\|)$, which is feasible for rank-one NFPA. Its projection coefficient is proportional to $\langle \mathrm{vec}(Z_i), t\otimes v\rangle$, the whitened matched-filter coefficient and hence the OF amplitude up to normalization.

Corollary 1 (Rank-one correspondence)**.** *Assume isotropic whitened noise and a unique leading population signal eigendirection separated by a nonzero eigengap. If that direction is generated by a separable template $\tilde{s} = vt^\top$, population NFPA with $k_1 = k_2 = 1$ learns $v/\|v\|$ and $t/\|t\|$ up to signs; its scalar code is proportional to the OF amplitude of Section 2.*

B Experiment details and reporting limits

The controlled NFPA experiment uses $C = 2$ channels, $T = 256$ samples, a sampling rate of $1\,\mathrm{kHz}$, channel weights $(1.0, 0.65)$, and amplitude $A \sim \mathcal{N}(1, 0.3^2)$. The noise is Brownian with $S_n(f) \propto 1/f^2$ and is whitened using the matched temporal frequency-domain filter. The train and test sets contain 800 and 300 events. NFPA and IsoAE use $(k_c, k_t) = (2, 3)$, while CW-PCA and IsoPCA use rank six.

Because $C = k_c = 2$, $U_cU_c^\top = I_2$ in this experiment: the reconstruction restricts a temporal subspace shared by both channels but does not compress the channel axis. Principal angles between NFPA and CW-PCA are $0.0°$, $59.3°$, $64.6°$, $73.8°$, $84.8°$, and $87.8°$ (mean $61.7°$). The corresponding IsoAE–CW-PCA angles are $82.1°$, $83.7°$, $86.0°$, $86.6°$, $88.2°$, and $89.4°$ (mean $86.0°$). These are point estimates from one seed and split. The exact held-out raw-MSE values for IsoAE and IsoPCA are re-exported at full precision from the archived run (4.58×10^{-9} and 4.33×10^{-9}).

B.1 TIDMAD rung-4 baselines

A submission-strength empirical study should repeat this comparison across seeds and train/test splits and sweep SNR, noise color, channel count, rank pair, and controlled nonseparability. It should report confidence intervals for held-out $\bar{\chi}^2$, raw MSE, and subspace angles. No such uncertainty estimate is claimed here.

Table 1: Implementation check: the single-split $C = k_c = 2$ run reported by the earlier draft, retained for provenance. $\bar{\chi}^2$ is the per-coordinate normalized whitened residual $\bar{\chi}^2$ of Section 2; $\bar{\theta}$ is the mean principal angle to CW-PCA in whitened space.

Method	Training	Class	$\bar{\chi}^2$	Raw MSE	$\bar{\theta}$
CW-PCA	Σ^{-1}	full	0.9929	4.95×10^{-3}	0°
NFPA	Σ^{-1}	factored	0.9916	4.95×10^{-3}	61.7°
IsoAE	MSE	factored	0.9995	4.58×10^{-9}	86.0°
IsoPCA	MSE	full	1.0007	4.33×10^{-9}	—

Table 2: TIDMAD coarse denoising scores (higher is better) from published baselines, the archived linear estimate, and this paper's two rung-4 arms, which share architecture, data, and budget and differ only in the training objective. The two arms return bit-identical values because the upstream aggregation rounds the raw score to 0.01 before the logarithm and both band-limited arms fall in the same bin; rescoring without the rounding gives 0.0241 vs. 0.0231 in band, a contrast whose bootstrap interval spans zero (Section 4). Band-limited arms are not comparable to the full-band published rows.

Method	Coarse score
FCNet	6.55
Transformer	4.18
PUNet	3.84
none	1.10 (1.1026)
linear Wiener (archived)	-1.8025
`T-mse`	-2.7708
`T-chi2`	-2.7708

B.2 Predeclared confirmatory protocol

Mean handling, all experiments: the training mean is estimated once, applied unchanged to held-out observations, and added back after reconstruction.

The multi-seed confirmatory study is predeclared before execution and tests three hypotheses. H1 (metric reversal at fixed architecture): under colored or correlated noise, NFPA and an isotropically trained multilinear projection with the same (k_c, k_t) should disagree in ranking, with paired across-seed confidence intervals excluding zero in the predicted directions. H2 (white-noise control): when $\Sigma = \sigma^2 I$, covariance-aware and Euclidean projectors should agree to numerical tolerance. H3 (active restriction): with $C > k_c$ and $T > k_t$, NFPA should recover the planted channel and temporal subspaces for separable signals. Truth-referenced recovery (an earlier fourth hypothesis) is now covered by the rung-4 amplitude error against TIDMAD's real injected reference channel and is not run synthetically. The primary configuration uses $C = 8$ channels, $T = 256$ samples, ranks $(k_c, k_t) = (2, 3)$, $800/400/2000$ training/validation/test events, 10 independent seeds, 10 ALS restarts per seed, SNR 10 under $\mathrm{SNR}^2 = \mathbb{E}[s^\top \Sigma^{-1} s]$, Brownian $1/f^2$ temporal noise with channel correlation, oracle covariance, and nonseparability $\alpha = 0.1$. Results enter the main text only if every acceptance gate holds: all seeds complete without post-result configuration changes; the fixed-architecture reversal intervals exclude zero in the predicted directions; the white-noise control passes its predeclared equivalence margin; and the table and figure are generated directly from archived seed-level results.

The factored representation (Section 3, generic form) has $O(k_1 n_1 + k_2 n_2)$ basis parameters rather than $O(k_1 k_2 n_1 n_2)$ for an unstructured basis, trading approximation flexibility for a two-axis inductive bias related to classical tensor factorizations [Kolda and Bader, 2009, Lu et al., 2008]. Alternating spectral updates solve each factor subproblem exactly, although the joint product-manifold objective remains nonconvex.

Rung-2 numbers carried from the companion work. In the 30-seed rank-two benchmark (512 traces of dimension 256 per seed), PCA and CW-PCA had held-out weighted residuals 48.419 and 47.869 (paired difference 0.550, $[0.530, 0.571]$) while raw MSE preferred the opposite reconstruction,

their whitened subspaces 86.25° apart. The ten-seed white-noise control gave a maximum angle of 1.48×10^{-6} degrees. On the TIDMAD file the amplitude RMSE fell from 0.1209 to 0.0880.